DSEH004 · PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT

Flow, Work Design and Purpose

Week 3 · Lecture 2 · Unit II · Optimal experience, the job characteristics model, prosocial impact and Indian frames of duty

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L2 · COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Meaningful work is something HR can give to employees.

Agree or disagree. If HR cannot give it, what can HR do?

Csikszentmihalyi: flow

CSIKSZENTMIHALYI (1990)

Conditions

Clear goals, immediate feedback, and a balance between challenge and skill.

CSIKSZENTMIHALYI AND LEFEVRE (1989)

The paradox of work

Experience sampling found flow more often at work than in leisure, yet people still wished to be elsewhere.

Flow is designed into tasks. A PM system that delays feedback for a year removes one of its conditions.

L2 · JOB CHARACTERISTICS MODEL

Hackman and Oldham (1976)

CORE DIMENSION	CRITICAL PSYCHOLOGICAL STATE
Skill variety, task identity, task significance	Experienced meaningfulness
Autonomy	Experienced responsibility for outcomes
Feedback from the job	Knowledge of results

Growth need strength moderates the effects. A meta analysis later added social characteristics such as interdependence and support.

Hackman and Oldham (1976); Humphrey, Nahrgang and Morgeson (2007)

L2 · PURPOSE MADE CONCRETE

Grant's beneficiary contact studies

The design

University fundraising callers briefly met a student whose scholarship their calls had funded.

The result

Callers who met the beneficiary more than doubled their time on the phone and raised substantially more money.

Grant et al. (2007), Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 103(1)

Pink, and the meaning of work

PINK (2009)

Drive

Autonomy, mastery and purpose: an accessible restatement of SDT and flow.

ROSSO, DEKAS AND WRZESNIEWSKI (2010)

Sources of meaning

The self, others, the work context and spiritual life all supply meaning, through distinct mechanisms.

EVIDENCE FIRST

Caution

A popular book is a bridge to the research, not a substitute for it.

Nishkama karma and SDT

BHAGAVAD GITA 2.47

The idea

Act fully, without attachment to the fruits of action. Value lies in the act performed as duty.

COMPARISON

Where it meets SDT

Close to autonomous motivation: the act is endorsed for its own worth, not for reward.

SINHA (2008)

Where it differs

Grounded in svadharma, one's duty in a role, rather than in personal choice.

A loom operator's repetitive shift

THEORY	DIAGNOSIS	DESIGN IT IMPLIES
Flow	Challenge below skill, feedback delayed	Raise challenge, give immediate feedback
Job characteristics	Low task identity and feedback	Enlarge the task, add feedback from the job
Prosocial purpose	No contact with who benefits	Connect operators to customers
Nishkama karma	Meaning located in the duty itself	Honor craft and role, not only output

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Sources for this lecture (1 of 2)

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